Proton

Product Design

Design Assignment

👋 Welcome!

We are currently looking for top design talent to join our team - and we believe you might be the right person for the role.
Now, we would love to see how you approach a real-world design challenge. This is not only a chance for us to gain a deeper understanding of your design thinking, problem-solving skills, and visual craft, but also an opportunity for you to experience the kind of UX challenges we tackle on the Inbox team.

The Problem

Users are increasingly overwhelmed by the relentless flow of incoming messages - especially through email. Important information often gets buried.

To cope, people rely on a patchwork of labels, stars, folders, send to self, and filters, yet even well-organized inboxes quickly descend into chaos. Without better ways to manage this influx, even the most organized inboxes can become chaotic, leading to missed information, decreased focus, and a persistent feeling of anxiety.

The Challenge

Pitch a design solution for a focused inbox experience that helps users:

- Stay in control of their incoming messages
- Surface and prioritize what’s truly important

- Skim or triage less relevant messages - without feeling overwhelmed

You can choose to:

- Redesign a portion of the existing Proton Mail experience
  or
- Propose an entirely new concept that re-imagines how people manage incoming communication.

What to Deliver

This task is designed to be completed in about **8 hours.**
Focus on clear thinking, thoughtful interaction design, and visual craft.

We know a perfect solution isn't realistic given the time and context. Feel free to make assumptions - just explain them clearly.

Your submission should include:

- **Short Rationale (max. 2 pages or slides)**
  Briefly explain:
  - What pain points you chose to address - and why
  - Who is the user you had in mind?
  - What guided your design decisions?

- **2–3 Key Screens (High-Fidelity Mock-ups)**
  - Showcase the core of your solution with clear, well-designed screens
  - If helpful, include more low-fidelity mockups or flows to explain the overall concept
  - Don't be afraid to push boundaries or explore unconventional ideas - and have fun!

- **Bonus (Optional)**:
  Include any of the following if relevant or helpful:
  - A mini visual design system or UI kit used in your work

- Illustrations that enhance the experience
- A micro-interaction animations that add delight or polish

Deadline

You have **7 days** to return your solution. We're not looking for perfection - we want to understand your thinking, your product sense, and your visual/UI skills.

Evaluation Criteria

We'll assess your work based on the following:

Presentation

- How clearly is the concept communicated?
- Is the structure of the submission easy to follow?
- Are visuals and explanations balanced and purposeful?

Quality of the Solution

- Does the solution effectively address the problem?
- Is it usable, intuitive, and grounded in real-world behavior?

Innovation

- Does the solution go beyond the obvious?
- Are bold ideas balanced with product sensibility?

Communication

- Is the level of detail appropriate (when to zoom in vs. stay high level)?
- Are assumptions and decisions well explained?

Visual Design

- Is the UI visually polished and well-structured?
- Are layout, typography, and spacing handled with care?

- Are interactions intuitive and aligned with the concept?

User Empathy

- Does the design reflect a clear understanding of user needs and context?
- Are user behaviors or scenarios used to anchor decisions?

Next Steps

Only candidates whose work stands out will be invited to present their solution to the team.
We're excited to hear you walk us through your thinking, design choices, and process in your own words.

The session will also include a Q&A that goes both ways - we'll ask about your work, and you'll have the chance to ask us about the team, the product, and how we work.

We're looking forward to seeing your work! If you have any questions or need clarification along the way, don't hesitate to reach out - we're happy to help.

Good luck, and enjoy the challenge! 🙌

Sincerely,
The Inbox Design Team